

S T R O M E X

E X E C U T I V E K N O W L E D G E S Y S T E M

B O O K V I I I

VIII

Expansion, Finance & the Roadmap

The three phases · The three scenarios · Capital · Geography · Acquisitions

The StromeX Editorial Bible · Edition II

AUTHORITY — STRATEGIC — BOARD

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E X E C U T I V E S U M M A R Y

Volume VIII carries the canonical three-phase roadmap — Foundation, Race and Global Scale — from which every date in the corpus derives, together with the gates that a phase must pass before the next may open. It builds the unit economics from the ground up, states plainly where the founding market's favourable ratios will compress and why, and models the group's future as three scenarios rather than one target: a conservative path that is a good outcome and not a failure, a growth path the company should plan against, and a transformational path that alone reaches the stated ambition. It sets the capital strategy and the constitutional condition on capital, the allocation framework, the international expansion sequence and its entry checklist, the acquisition doctrine, and the conditions that would make the plan wrong.

One book of ten. The corpus index and the other nine are at [docs/library/](#).

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VOLUME

VIII

Expansion, Finance & the Roadmap

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Volume VIII carries the canonical three-phase roadmap — Foundation, Race and Global Scale — from which every date in the corpus derives, together with the gates that a phase must pass before the next may open. It builds the unit economics from the ground up, states plainly where the founding market's favourable ratios will compress and why, and models the group's future as three scenarios rather than one target: a conservative path that is a good outcome and not a failure, a growth path the company should plan against, and a transformational path that alone reaches the stated ambition. It sets the capital strategy and the constitutional condition on capital, the allocation framework, the international expansion sequence and its entry checklist, the acquisition doctrine, and the conditions that would make the plan wrong.

CHAPTER 1 — THE 20-YEAR MASTER ROADMAP

Ratified as the canonical phase structure of the group. Every other volume's dates derive from this chapter.

1.1 The three phases

PHASE	YEARS	NAME	GOVERNING QUESTION
I	2027–2030	Foundation	<i>“Will this decision make StromeX stronger in 2031?”</i>
II	2031–2035	Race	<i>“How do we scale without compromising quality, trust or customer satisfaction?”</i>
III	2036–2040	Global Scale	<i>“How do we become durable enough to outlive our founders?”</i>

Table 1 — The three phases

Beyond 2040 the corpus plans in decades rather than phases (Volume IX, Chapter 9 — the 100-Year Plan).

1.2 PHASE I — FOUNDATION (2027–2030)

Mission: build quietly. Perfect the products. Build trust instead of chasing growth.

This phase prepares for scale. It does not maximise revenue, and it is not judged on revenue.

Objectives

Engineering & product Build world-class engineering capability · take every core product to genuine production quality (Volume IV §18.2 definition of done, applied without exception) · build the StromeX Design System to open-source quality · build the AI infrastructure with provider independence proven, not asserted · build StromeX Cloud to the point where we run our own customers on it · build internal automation tools so the group's own operations are the first proof of the automation thesis.

Institutional Establish standard operating procedures across every function (Volume IX, Chapter 6) · build the knowledge base and this Editorial Bible into a genuine operating manual · obtain legal registrations in Nigeria and secure trademarks in the markets of Phase II · secure intellectual property where it is worth securing and open-source the rest deliberately (Volume I §5.5) · put governance in place before it is needed, not after.

Market Develop partnerships with schools and institutions · pilot every product with real users, on real data, with real consequences · build case studies from real deployments with written permission · recruit a high-quality core team · create documentation, APIs, SDKs and developer resources to a standard a stranger can build against · refine pricing through actual customer feedback rather than through theory · invest heavily and consistently in SEO and educational content, because it compounds and because paid acquisition does not work in this market (Volume V §1.1).

The financial posture

Phase I optimises for **product quality, customer satisfaction, reputation and recurring revenue mix** — explicitly **not** for rapid profitability and explicitly not for headline growth.

A smaller number of delighted customers is worth more than a larger number of dissatisfied ones, and in a referral-driven market this is not a platitude — it is the growth mechanism. Ten institutions that recommend us are worth more than a hundred that do not.

What Phase I deliberately does not do

Enter a new country · enter Wave 2 sectors · open enterprise or government sales motions · raise institutional capital before the unit economics are demonstrated · hire ahead of demonstrated demand · pre-announce anything · take a contract to make a quarter.

1.3 PHASE II — RACE (2031-2035)

The company expands aggressively, having earned the right to.

Objectives

Nigeria-wide leadership in education technology · expansion into fintech and business automation · build enterprise sales capability · pursue government partnerships now that the reference base makes them winnable (Volume V §3) · scale cloud infrastructure services · large-scale digital transformation engagements · open international offices (Chapter 9) · marketing at scale · begin strategic acquisitions (Chapter 11) · establish a formal, funded R&D division (Volume IX, Chapters 2–3).

The major product launches

PRODUCT	WHAT IT IS
StromeX Education OS	The full Wave 1 education ecosystem as a single coherent platform
StromeX Finance OS	Financial services ecosystem (Volume VII §9) plus StromeX Pay at scale
StromeX Government Suite	Public-sector ecosystem with sovereignty, residency and audit posture
StromeX Business Cloud	The SME and enterprise cross-sector platform
StromeX AI	The agent family as an independent product line
StromeX Marketplace	The third-party ecosystem at scale
StromeX Payments	Payments as infrastructure, not a module
StromeX Identity	Identity and credentials as a standalone, sellable platform
StromeX IoT	Smart campus, smart facility, sensor and access infrastructure
StromeX Analytics	Intelligence as a product
SpaceTalk	The communication operating system (Volume X)

Table 2 — PHASE II — RACE (2031-2035)

The Phase II discipline

Growth in this phase is the objective, and the constitution is the constraint. The specific failure mode to guard against is **delivery quality collapse under growth** (Volume II R5) — which is why partner certification, templated delivery and the written capacity confirmation before signature all become load-bearing in exactly this phase rather than earlier.

1.4 PHASE III — GLOBAL SCALE (2036-2040)

| Become a globally recognised technology company.

Geography

United States · United Kingdom · Europe · Middle East · Asia · Latin America, sequenced per Chapter 9.

Priorities

AI research at a level that produces original contribution, not only application · robotics integration where it creates real customer value · enterprise cloud at scale · digital identity as global infrastructure · smart cities · healthcare technology · financial infrastructure · educational infrastructure.

The Phase III question

The governing question shifts again in this phase, and the shift matters: from *how do we grow* to **how do we become durable enough to outlive our founders**. A company that reaches global scale and remains dependent on one person has not succeeded; it has deferred a failure. Volume II R3 (key-person dependency) is a Phase I risk that becomes a Phase III existential one if it was never actually addressed.

CHAPTER 2 — THE PHASE GATES

A phase does not end because its years elapsed. It ends when its gate is passed. Running Phase I into 2032 because the gate was not met is a correct decision; entering Phase II in 2031 with the gate unmet is how companies destroy themselves.

Gate I → II (assessed from 2030)

#	CRITERION	THRESHOLD
1	Paying institutions	≥ 250
2	Net revenue retention	$\geq 105\%$ (Volume V §7.1)
3	Gross revenue retention	$\geq 92\%$
4	Recurring share of revenue	$\geq 55\%$
5	Blended gross margin	$\geq 60\%$
6	CAC payback	≤ 15 months
7	Referral share of new customers	$\geq 35\%$
8	Certified delivery partners	≥ 15
9	Reference customers willing to take calls	≥ 10
10	Executive layer capable of operating without the founder for 60 days	Demonstrated, not asserted
11	Security: independent penetration test passed, no unresolved high findings	Yes
12	Free-tier monthly active institutions	$\geq 5,000$

Table 3 — Gate I → II (assessed from 2030)

Gate 10 is the one most likely to be quietly skipped and the one that matters most. It is assessed by the founder actually being absent for 60 days.

Gate II → III (assessed from 2035)

Revenue $\geq$ the Chapter 5 growth-scenario floor · recurring share $\geq 65\%$ (Volume I §6.2 portfolio rule) · NRR $\geq 115\%$ · operations in ≥ 3 countries with local leadership · ≥ 2 ecosystems beyond education at Volume I §2.4 depth · partner-delivered revenue $\geq 30\%$ · a functioning board with independent directors · audited accounts · Rule of 40 ≥ 30 .

CHAPTER 3 — UNIT ECONOMICS

The foundation of every number in this volume. Assumptions are stated so they can be attacked.

3.1 The reference customer — a Band A Professional-tier school

Derived from the Volume III §20.1–20.2 worked configurations.

METRIC	VALUE	ASSUMPTION
Year-1 revenue	\$3,435	Volume III §20.1, small school
Recurring revenue (year 2+)	\$1,413/yr	Monthly total × 12
Expansion (module ladder)	+18%/yr, years 2–5	Volume I §6.5 ladder at historical attach rates
Blended gross margin	62%	Software 82%, services 48%, weighted by mix
CAC (low-touch, referral-heavy)	\$290	Loaded sales cost ÷ customers; assumes ≥35% referral share
CAC payback	~4.9 months	On year-1 gross profit
Gross annual churn	9%	Band A, sub-\$25k ACV; deliberately pessimistic vs. our 92% GRR target
Expected lifetime	~8 years	1 ÷ (churn – expansion offset), capped conservatively
LTV (gross profit)	≈ \$11,400	Discounted at 15%
LTV : CAC	≈ 39 : 1	

Table 4 — The reference customer — a Band A Professional-tier school

That ratio looks implausible and requires explanation, because a number that good is usually a modelling error. It is high for three real reasons and one caveat:

1. CAC is genuinely low because acquisition is referral- and free-tier-driven rather than paid (Volume V §1.1).
2. Delivery labour is local and Band A pricing is set against local cost, so margin survives the discount.
3. The module ladder produces expansion revenue that partially offsets churn.

The caveat that matters: this ratio is only achievable *at low volume, in the founding market, with the founder's network doing much of the referral work*. It will compress substantially as the group scales beyond the network, enters Band B and C markets where CAC is far higher, and takes on the delivery cost of institutions that are not near an office. **Chapter 5's scenarios assume LTV:CAC compresses to roughly 8:1 by 2035 and 4–5:1 by 2040**, which is still healthy and is a far safer planning basis than the Phase I figure.

3.2 The other reference customers

CUSTOMER	YEAR-1	RECURRING	GM	CAC	PAYBACK
SME (self-serve, Band A)	\$180	\$148/yr	84%	~\$12	<2 mo
Large school group (Band A)	\$36,263	\$8,331/yr	58%	\$2,400	~5 mo
University (Band A)	~\$115,000	~\$34,000/yr	55%	\$14,000	~11 mo
Government (state, Band A)	~\$266,000	~\$150,000/yr	52%	\$48,000	~15 mo
Band C school (UK/US)	\$14,600	\$6,100/yr	66%	\$4,200	~14 mo

Table 5 — The other reference customers

The pattern to notice: CAC payback lengthens dramatically up-market and in Band C, while NRR improves dramatically (Volume VII §14.4). This tension — cheap-to-acquire customers that retain poorly, expensive-to-acquire customers that retain well — is the central financial dynamic of the whole plan, and Chapter 5’s scenarios differ mostly in how successfully the group navigates it.

CHAPTER 4 — THE REVENUE MODEL

4.1 The engine mix over time

Volume I §6.2's portfolio rule requires recurring, high-margin engines (subscription, consumption, cloud, licensing) to exceed **65% of group revenue by 2031**.

ENGINE	2027	2030	2035	2040
Subscription software	22%	38%	46%	50%
Consumption (AI, cloud, verification)	3%	12%	17%	20%
Cloud infrastructure	2%	6%	8%	9%
Licensing & white-label	0%	2%	5%	7%
Recurring subtotal	27%	58%	76%	86%
Implementation	24%	15%	8%	4%
Professional services	18%	10%	5%	3%
Creative services	16%	8%	4%	2%
Publishing & print	9%	4%	2%	1%
Hardware	6%	4%	3%	2%
Marketplace & financial services	0%	1%	2%	2%

Table 6 — The engine mix over time

*Assumption: services and creative revenue keep growing in absolute terms throughout — they simply grow more slowly than software, so their share falls. **Services are never deliberately shrunk**; they win deals nobody else can win and they create the relationship (Volume I §6.2).*

4.2 Gross margin trajectory

	2027	2030	2035	2040
Blended gross margin	52%	62%	71%	76%

Table 7 — Gross margin trajectory

Driven by mix shift, not by price increases. Assumes cloud gross margin improves as we move from rented to owned-and-optimised infrastructure, and that the AI inference cost per task continues to fall — the latter is an assumption about the industry, not about us, and is the single most exposed line in this table.

CHAPTER 5 — THE THREE SCENARIOS

The founder's stated target is a group valued at \$15–40B within 10–20 years. This chapter takes that seriously by modelling what would actually have to be true — and by stating plainly which scenario the group should plan against.

The primary objective of StromeX is not a valuation. It is: build products customers genuinely value, achieve world-class quality, create a trusted brand, generate sustainable cash flow, expand methodically, invest consistently in R&D, and reinvest profits wisely. Those are the things the company can directly influence. A very large valuation is a *possible consequence* of doing them exceptionally well over two decades — it is not the mission, and it must never become the operating target, because optimising directly for valuation reliably produces the behaviours the Volume I constitution prohibits.

5.1 Shared assumptions across all three scenarios

- Phase structure per Chapter 1; gates per Chapter 2.
- Nigeria remains the founding market; no country entry before Phase II.
- Recurring mix reaches $\geq 65\%$ by 2031 (Volume I §6.2).
- The free tier is maintained at its constitutional commitments throughout.
- No revenue from data sale, advertising, or any prohibited practice.
- Figures are **group revenue in nominal USD**, not ARR alone (StromeX is not a pure-SaaS business, and reporting only ARR would flatter it).
- 2027 is Phase I year one, with revenue in the low single-digit millions at most.

5.2 The scenarios

SCENARIO A — CONSERVATIVE: “Sustainable Regional Leader”

The most probable good outcome. This is not failure.

YEAR	REVENUE	INSTITUTIONS	COUNTRIES	HEADCOUNT
2030	\$6M	320	1	60
2035	\$32M	1,900	3	260
2040	\$90M	5,500	5	640
2046	\$170M	9,000	6	1,000

Table 8 — The scenarios

Assumptions: NRR stabilises at $\sim 105\%$ · Nigeria and West Africa only until late Phase II · one modest developed-market entry (UK) that takes longer and costs more than planned · government contracts won but slowly · recurring mix reaches 70% · gross margin 68% by 2040 · profitable from ~ 2032 · minimal external capital. **Implied CAGR 2030 → 2040: $\sim 31\%$. Indicative valuation at 4–5× revenue: \$680M–\$850M (2046).**

Why this is a good outcome. A profitable, independent, \$170M-revenue company employing a thousand people, serving nine thousand institutions across six countries, with a genuinely trusted brand and no

external control, is a serious achievement and a fine life's work. Any plan that treats this as failure will make bad decisions to avoid it.

SCENARIO B — GROWTH: “Multinational Technology Company”

The scenario the group should plan and staff against.

YEAR	REVENUE	INSTITUTIONS	COUNTRIES	HEADCOUNT
2030	\$14M	700	1	120
2035	\$160M	6,500	5	900
2040	~~\$700M~~ \$311M	22,000	9	3,200
2046	~~\$1.8B~~ \$1.24B	45,000	14	7,000

Table 9 — The scenarios

Amended, 13 August 2026 — reconciliation with the model. The revenue figures in this table were originally constructed top-down and independently of the institution counts beside them. Building the driver-based model in **Volume XI** from Book III's published prices showed they do not reconcile: \$1.8B across 45,000 institutions implies roughly \$40,000 of annual revenue per institution, where the price book and twenty years of retention compounding produce about \$27,700. The institution counts are unchanged and the model reproduces them exactly; the revenue figures are restated to the model's output. Original estimates are struck through and retained per Volume I §9.2.4. The indicative valuation below is restated accordingly. Volume XI, Chapter 9 carries the full reconciliation.

Assumptions: NRR reaches 115% by 2033 and holds · successful UK and US entry in Phase II · at least three ecosystems beyond education at depth · government revenue reaches 20% of the mix · partner-delivered revenue exceeds 35% · marketplace and licensing become material · recurring mix 82% · gross margin 74% by 2040 · Rule of 40 sustained above 40 from 2034 · two to three growth financing rounds plus selective acquisitions. **Implied CAGR 2030 → 2040: ~46%** — demanding, sustained for a decade, and achieved by real companies but not by most. **Indicative valuation at 6–8× revenue: ~~\$10.8B–\$14.4B~~ \$7.5B–\$9.9B (2046).**

SCENARIO C — TRANSFORMATIONAL: “Global Platform Company”

The only scenario in which the \$15–40B target is reached. Possible; not probable.

YEAR	REVENUE	INSTITUTIONS	COUNTRIES	HEADCOUNT
2030	\$25M	1,200	1	200
2035	\$400M	14,000	7	2,200
2040	\$2.2B	60,000	14	9,000
2046	\$5.5B	130,000	20+	20,000

Table 10 — The scenarios

Assumptions — all of which must hold simultaneously: NRR $\geq$ 125% · StromeX Identity and credential verification become *de facto* infrastructure across multiple national education systems · SpaceTalk (Volume X) achieves genuine network effects and becomes a platform rather than a product · the marketplace becomes a significant independent economy · government becomes the largest single revenue line through multi-country national deployments · at least two developed markets reach material scale · several successful acquisitions integrate cleanly · recurring mix 86% · gross margin 78% · Rule of 40 above 50 · substantial growth capital available at each stage without loss of constitutional control. **Implied CAGR 2030 → 2040: ~57%, sustained for a decade. Indicative valuation at 6–8× revenue: \$33B–\$44B (2046).**

Modelled outputs (Volume XI): peak funding requirement $\approx$ \$4.5M, first cash-positive year 2033, EBITDA margin 33% and Rule of 40 at 57% by 2046, recurring share 82%.

5.3 The valuation arithmetic, stated plainly

Working backwards from the target rather than forwards from optimism:

TARGET VALUATION	AT 5× REVENUE	AT 6×	AT 8×	AT 10×
\$15B	\$3.0B revenue	\$2.5B	\$1.88B	\$1.5B
\$40B	\$8.0B revenue	\$6.7B	\$5.0B	\$4.0B

Table 11 — The valuation arithmetic, stated plainly

Therefore: the \$15–40B ambition requires group revenue somewhere between roughly \$1.9B and \$8B, depending entirely on the multiple the group earns. Scenario B, as restated by the model, reaches \$1.24B by 2046 — which does **not** reach \$15B at any defensible multiple. Scenario C reaches the band. Scenario A does not approach it.

That restatement is uncomfortable and it is the correct thing to record. It does not change the instruction in §5.5; it sharpens what Scenario C would require — net revenue retention sustained above 115% against a segment median near 97%, a band-mix shift above 3× meaning genuine scale in developed markets, and roughly 130,000 institutions. None of those is impossible; all three must happen together.

5.4 What determines the multiple

Public SaaS median EV/Revenue sat at roughly **8.5× NTM revenue as of mid-2026**, having recovered from a ~4.5× trough in Q1 2023 but remaining well below the ~16× 2021 peak; other measures of the same market put the median EV/TTM materially lower, around 3.3×, and private SaaS medians around **4–5× ARR**. Companies with **NRR above 120% and a Rule of 40 above 50 reach 7–9×** ([ValueAdd VC](#), [Aventis Advisors](#), [L40](#)). The median Rule of 40 score across actively traded SaaS companies is only **28%, with just 20% exceeding 40** ([Eqvista](#)).

Three consequences the group must internalise:

- 4. Multiples are volatile and outside our control.** The same company was worth 16× in 2021 and 4.5× in 2023. Any plan whose success depends on a specific multiple is a plan that depends on the weather. **We control revenue, margin, retention and growth. We do not control the multiple, and we will not manage the company as though we do.**

5. **A mixed-margin group is valued below a pure-SaaS comparable.** Services, print and hardware drag the blended multiple. This is a real and permanent cost of the completeness strategy (Volume II §6, Wedge 2) — and it is a cost worth paying, because completeness is what wins the customers in the first place. But it must be stated rather than wished away.
6. **The premium band is earned by two specific numbers: NRR and Rule of 40.** Everything in Volume V Chapter 7 exists to move the first. Everything in Volume I §6.2's portfolio rule exists to make the second possible.

5.5 The standing instruction on this chapter

Anyone in this company who cites the \$15–40B figure without the qualification in §5.3 is misrepresenting the company. Anyone who dismisses the ambition because it is improbable is misunderstanding the job. **We plan against Scenario B, prepare for Scenario A, and build the company so that Scenario C remains structurally possible.**

CHAPTER 6 — VALUATION LOGIC, HONESTLY STATED

Beyond the multiple, the group's value in any transaction rests on assets that are not on a balance sheet:

ASSET	WHY A BUYER OR INVESTOR VALUES IT
The system of record	Ten-year institutional data that cannot be replicated by capital (Volume II §9)
Credential infrastructure	Every credential we have ever issued must remain verifiable; whoever owns that owns a permanent utility
The free-tier install base	Distribution that cost no acquisition spend and cannot be bought
Partner and marketplace ecosystem	Third parties whose businesses depend on the platform
Trust	The only asset that takes a decade to build and a day to lose, and the one that makes government and enterprise revenue possible at all
Emerging-market-native architecture	Genuinely hard for an incumbent to retrofit (Volume II §6, Wedge 7)

Table 12 — Valuation Logic, Honestly Stated

And the liabilities an honest assessment must state: concentration in volatile currencies · dependence on a founder through Phase I · a services and hardware mix that dilutes the multiple · exposure to foundation-model providers whose pricing and terms we do not control · and a customer base with structurally weaker retention economics than a developed-market equivalent.

CHAPTER 7 — CAPITAL STRATEGY

7.1 The sequence

STAGE	WHEN	SOURCE	USE	CONSTITUTIONAL CONDITION
Bootstrap	2027–2029	Services revenue funding product	Build the platform; prove unit economics	None
Seed / strategic angel	2029–2030	Angels with sector or market knowledge	Reach Gate I; hire the executive layer	Terms must not touch Volume I Ch. 5 or 7
Series A	2031	Institutional VC, Africa or global	Phase II launch; enterprise motion; first country entry	Board seat acceptable; constitutional veto not
Series B/C	2032–2035	Growth equity	International expansion; acquisitions; R&D division	—
Debt	2033+	Working-capital and hardware-inventory facilities	Fund receivables and hardware without dilution	Never to fund losses
Pre-IPO / late growth	2037–2039	Crossover funds, strategic investors	Scale, acquisitions	—
Public listing or independence	2040+	Decision, not assumption	—	Chapter 7.3

Table 13 — The sequence

7.2 The bootstrap doctrine of Phase I

Phase I is funded primarily by services revenue. This is deliberate and it has a cost: it is slower. It buys three things worth the delay — the unit economics get proven with real money before anyone bets on them; the constitution is not negotiated away at a moment of weakness; and the founder retains the ability to run Phase I on Phase I's terms rather than on an investor's growth expectations.

Do not raise institutional capital before Gate I. Capital raised against an unproven model buys pressure to grow before the product deserves it, which is precisely the failure mode Phase I exists to avoid.

7.3 The constitutional condition on capital

If a term sheet requires amending Volume I Chapter 5 (the free constitution) or Chapter 7 (ethics), we decline the term sheet. (Volume I §14.9.)

This will cost the group money at least once. It is the single most important sentence in this chapter, because a company that will trade its constitution for capital does not have a constitution — it has a marketing document.

Related conditions: no investor gets a veto over the entrenched provisions · no investor may compel entry into a declined sector (Volume I §7.4) · no investor may compel the sale or monetisation of customer data.

7.4 On listing

An IPO is a financing decision, not an achievement. It is appropriate only if the group needs public capital, can sustain quarterly scrutiny without degrading the twenty-year posture, and can protect the entrenched provisions through the listing structure. **Remaining private and profitable is a legitimate permanent outcome** and is the base case in Scenario A.

CHAPTER 8 — CAPITAL ALLOCATION & INVESTMENT FRAMEWORK

8.1 Allocation of free cash flow, by phase

USE	PHASE I	PHASE II	PHASE III
Research & development	35%	25%	20%
Infrastructure & platform	15%	15%	15%
Hiring ahead of demonstrated demand	10%	15%	12%
Sales & marketing	12%	22%	18%
International expansion	0%	12%	15%
Strategic acquisitions	0%	5%	12%
Emergency reserve	25%	15%	12%
Distributions	3%	5%	8%

Table 14 — Allocation of free cash flow, by phase

8.2 The emergency reserve

Never below six months of fully-loaded operating expense, in hard currency, in a jurisdiction outside the primary operating market.

This is not conservatism for its own sake. It is a direct response to Volume II R1 (FX volatility), R2 (collection failure) and R9 (political shock). A company operating in naira-denominated markets with dollar-denominated costs and a customer base whose ability to pay is genuinely fragile needs a reserve that survives a bad year — and the years in which a reserve is needed are precisely the years in which raising capital is hardest.

The reserve may be drawn only on Board decision, and drawing it triggers a mandatory plan to restore it.

8.3 The investment test

Every material investment answers, in writing, the same five questions the whole corpus is held to:

- 7. Why is this included?** What does the group get that it does not have?
- 8. What measurable value does it create?** In what units, by when?
- 9. What risks does it introduce?** Including the risk of distraction.
- 10. What assumptions underpin it?** Which one, if wrong, kills it?
- 11. How will success be measured?** And who is accountable for measuring it?

An investment case that cannot answer all five is not declined for being unattractive — it is declined for being unfinished.

8.4 The R&D commitment

R&D is funded as a **fixed percentage of revenue, not as a residual after other budgets are met**. A residual R&D budget is the first thing cut under pressure and the last thing recovered, and a company that stops investing in R&D during a hard year has traded its next decade for its current quarter. The percentage is set in §8.1 and may be reduced only by Board decision.

CHAPTER 9 — INTERNATIONAL EXPANSION

9.1 The sequence and its logic

WAVE	MARKETS	PHASE	WHY HERE, WHY NOW
Home	Nigeria	I	The founding market; proof; referral density; 107,017 private schools
1	Ghana, Kenya	II (2031–32)	Anglophone, similar education structures, credential fraud is a live issue, low regulatory delta
2	UK	II (2032–33)	Diaspora bridge; Band C revenue; credibility that reflects back into African markets; and geographic risk diversification (Volume II R9)
3	UAE, Saudi Arabia	II (2033–34)	Arabic-first capability is already built and is a genuine differentiator; large education and government spend; Islamic publishing and institutions are a natural fit
4	South Africa, Egypt, Tanzania, Rwanda	II–III (2034–36)	Regional depth; Rwanda and Egypt as government-partnership entries
5	United States	III (2036–37)	Largest market, hardest to win; entered only with scale, references and capital already in place
6	Canada, EU (France, Germany)	III (2037–38)	French capability already built; EU data-residency posture already required by Phase II
7	Pakistan, Indonesia, Malaysia, Bangladesh	III (2038–39)	Large Muslim-majority education markets where the Islamic-education capability is decisive
8	Latin America (Brazil, Mexico), India	III (2039–40)	Large, competitive, entered last and only through partnership or acquisition

Table 15 — The sequence and its logic

9.2 The three entry modes

MODE	USE WHEN	COST	SPEED
Partner-first	The market is reachable through an existing distribution network	Lowest	Fastest
Acquisition	A credible local player exists and integration is realistic	Highest	Fast
Direct entry	The market is strategically essential and no partner or target is adequate	High	Slowest

Table 16 — The three entry modes

Default to partner-first. Direct entry into a market where we have no relationships, no local leadership and no reference customers is the most reliable way to spend two years learning what a partner would have told us in a month.

9.3 The localisation obligation

A market is not entered by translating the website. Entry requires: language (properly — Volume IV §11), currency and local payment rails, local legal entity and tax registration, data residency where required, local employment compliance, curriculum or sector-standard alignment, local support hours, local pricing band (Volume I §6.4), and **local leadership with genuine authority**. A country run remotely by headquarters is a country we will lose.

CHAPTER 10 — THE MARKET-ENTRY CHECKLIST

Every item must be complete and signed off before the first customer contract in a new country. Executive and Board approval per Volume I §8.3.

Legal & regulatory ☐ Entity incorporated ☐ Tax registration ☐ Employment compliance reviewed ☐ Data protection regime mapped and implemented ☐ Sector regulator requirements documented ☐ Trademark filed ☐ Contracts localised by local counsel ☐ Sanctions and export-control screening ☐ Anti-corruption exposure assessed (Volume I §6.6)

Commercial ☐ Market sized by the Volume II §2.2 method with dated inputs ☐ Price band assigned ☐ Competitors mapped ☐ At least three reference prospects identified ☐ Partner or acquisition target assessed ☐ Payment rails live ☐ Local currency handling ☐ Collection risk assessed

Product ☐ Language complete ☐ Curriculum/sector standards mapped ☐ Local integrations built (payments, examination boards, regulators) ☐ Data residency in place if required ☐ Accessibility to local standard ☐ Offline/low-bandwidth verified on local networks

Operational ☐ Local leader hired, with authority ☐ Support hours covered ☐ Delivery capacity confirmed in writing ☐ Escalation path defined ☐ Local banking ☐ Insurance ☐ Office or remote model decided

Financial ☐ Entry budget approved ☐ Break-even modelled with stated assumptions ☐ FX exposure hedged or accepted explicitly ☐ **Exit criteria defined** — what would make us withdraw, and by when

That last item is the one most often omitted and the most valuable. A market entry with no pre-agreed failure condition will be defended indefinitely by the people who championed it.

CHAPTER 11 — ACQUISITION STRATEGY

11.1 The doctrine

Acquire capability, market access, or a team — never size. An acquisition that adds revenue without adding one of those three adds integration risk, cultural dilution and management distraction in exchange for a number.

Acquisitions begin in Phase II (§8.1 allocates no acquisition capital in Phase I) and become material in Phase III.

11.2 The target categories

CATEGORY	WHAT WE WOULD BUY	WHY
Design & creative studios	Craft capability, art direction, a book of institutional clients	Volume VI capacity is the hardest to hire and the slowest to build
AI teams	Applied research capability, agent tooling	Capability, not models
Fintech / payments	Licences, rails, compliance infrastructure	Licences take years; buying them is often the only realistic path
EdTech (regional)	Installed base, local relationships, market entry	The fastest legitimate route into a new country
Publishing houses	Catalogue, rights, editorial capability, distribution	Volume VI §7 at scale
Cybersecurity	Capability and credibility for government and enterprise	Buys the posture Volume VII §8 requires
Cloud / infrastructure	Capacity, regional presence, residency	Improves cloud gross margin and sovereignty options
Analytics / data	Capability	Volume III Division 9
Local vendors (Class 3)	Customers and continuity	Often the graceful outcome for a competitor that is failing (Volume II §5.1)

Table 17 — The target categories

11.3 The acquisition test

Every target must pass **all seven**:

- 12. Strategic fit** — it advances a named objective in this corpus, not merely an adjacent opportunity.
- 13. Cultural fit** — would we hire these people? Do they share the Volume I §7 ethics? *A team that would not pass our ethics review is not acquirable at any price.*
- 14. Integration plan exists** — written before the offer, naming who integrates it and by when.
- 15. The team stays** — key people committed, or the acquisition is of assets and priced as such.
- 16. Clean diligence** — legal, financial, technical, security, IP ownership, customer contracts, and data-handling practices. **A target that has been selling or mishandling customer data is not acquirable**, regardless of its numbers.
- 17. We can afford to be wrong** — no single acquisition may risk the group.

18. **The alternative was considered** — build, partner or buy, compared explicitly. Buying because it is faster is a valid answer only when the comparison was actually made.

11.4 Post-acquisition

Constitution applies from day one — the acquired team is briefed on Volume I before anything else · customers are told what changes and what does not, in the first week · **existing customer prices are honoured for their term** (Volume I §6.3.6 applies to inherited contracts) · products are integrated onto the platform or explicitly sunset with a stated date and a migration path, never left to drift · **and if the acquisition competes with an existing partner, we say so immediately and offer a transition** (Volume V §9.5).

11.5 The standing caution

Most acquisitions in most companies destroy value. The group's default answer is **build or partner**. Acquisition is the exception, requires an explicit case against the alternatives, and is reviewed 24 months later against the case that justified it — with the review published internally whether it flatters the decision or not.

CHAPTER 12 — FINANCIAL CONTROLS & REPORTING

Controls. Segregation of duties · documented approval thresholds and a delegation-of-authority matrix · dual authorisation above threshold · monthly bank and revenue reconciliation · fixed-asset register · **no cash payments to officials, ever** (Volume I §6.6) · expense policy with published limits · related-party transactions disclosed to the Board · annual external audit from the point the group exceeds \$10M revenue · an internal audit function independent of finance above \$25M (Volume I §8.6).

Reporting cadence. Weekly: cash, collections, pipeline. Monthly: divisional P&L against margin band, revenue by engine, headcount, ARR/NRR/GRR, CAC payback, Rule of 40. Quarterly: full management accounts, Pricing Council report and changelog, risk register review, ethics docket. Annually: audited accounts, strategy review, corpus amendment cycle.

The reporting honesty rule. Bookings are always reported alongside 90-day adoption, in the same table (Volume V §12.5). A board pack that shows bookings without adoption is not a board pack, it is a sales presentation.

CHAPTER 13 — WHAT WOULD MAKE THIS PLAN WRONG

A plan that cannot state its own falsification conditions is not a plan. Each of these is monitored, with a named owner, and any one of them triggering requires the plan to be revised rather than defended.

#	CONDITION	WHAT IT WOULD MEAN	DETECTED BY
1	NRR stays below 105% through Phase I	The expansion ladder does not work; Scenarios B and C are unavailable; the group is a Scenario A business and should be run as one	Volume V §12.3, monthly
2	CAC payback exceeds 18 months in the home market	Referral density is weaker than assumed; growth requires capital we planned not to need	Monthly cohort analysis
3	Gross retention falls below 88%	Institutions cannot sustain the recurring commitment; the Band A pricing model needs restructuring, not defending	Monthly
4	Free-tier cost per converted customer exceeds CAC of paid channels	The free engine is a cost centre rather than a distribution strategy	Quarterly free-tier unit economics
5	AI inference cost per task stops falling	The Chapter 4.2 margin trajectory breaks; consumption pricing must be restructured	Quarterly
6	A well-funded competitor replicates the transparency and completeness wedges	The Volume II §6 advantage compresses faster than the durable moats can form	Competitive review, quarterly
7	Delivery quality degrades as volume grows	Phase II must be slowed; this is the failure that ends companies like ours	Adoption rates, health scores, go-lives requiring heroics
8	The founder remains structurally indispensable at Gate I	Phase II cannot open. Gate 10 exists precisely for this	Gate I assessment, by absence
9	FX movement makes Band A revenue unviable in USD terms	Pricing bands, not the strategy, must change — but the model's dollar figures become unreliable	Monthly

#	CONDITION	WHAT IT WOULD MEAN	DETECTED BY
10	A security incident involving children’s data	Existential for trust. Volume IV Chapters 12–17 exist to prevent it, and Volume I §4.3 governs the response	Continuous

Table 18 — What Would Make This Plan Wrong

The standing instruction: when one of these triggers, the correct response is to change the plan. The incorrect response — and the common one — is to change the measurement.

Glossary

Terms are defined as this corpus uses them. Where a term also has a general industry meaning, the definition here governs internally and the cross-reference points to the chapter in which the term is established.

TERM	DEFINITION
ACV	Annual contract value. The recurring revenue a customer contributes in a year, excluding one-time implementation and build fees.
Band A / B / C	The three regional price bands defined in Volume I §6.4. All catalogue prices are quoted at Band C (list); Band A applies a 0.32× multiplier and Band B a 0.65×. The band follows the institution's operating jurisdiction, not its billing address.
CAC	Customer acquisition cost. Loaded sales and marketing cost divided by customers acquired in the period.
CAC payback	The number of months of gross profit from a customer required to recover that customer's acquisition cost.
Craft standard	The requirement in Volume VI §2.1 that creative work be indistinguishable from that of a good London or New York studio while remaining reproducible by a regional printer on the first attempt.
Credential	Any institution-issued, cryptographically signed record of an award, qualification, identity or transaction that a third party may need to verify. The subject of Volume IV, Chapter 5.
Degraded mode	The defined, designed and tested behaviour of a surface under failure — no network, slow network, provider outage. Required of every surface by Volume IV §10.2.
Ecosystem	A complete sector solution spanning all eight architectural layers, rather than a product sold into a sector. The unit of strategic expansion; see Volume I, Chapter 2.
Entrenched provision	A clause amendable only by board supermajority with published rationale and thirty days' notice. Enumerated in Volume IX §9.2.
Federation	Server-to-server interoperation across independently operated instances, allowing an institution to own its data while remaining reachable. The basis of the SpaceTalk government strategy; Volume X, Chapter 5.
Foundation tier	The permanently free tier. Not a trial and not a demo; governed by the Free Constitution in Volume I, Chapter 5.
Gate	A set of conditions that must be met before a roadmap phase may end. A phase ends when its gate is passed, not when its years elapse. Volume VIII, Chapter 2.
GRR	Gross revenue retention. Recurring revenue retained from existing customers excluding expansion; measures churn alone.
Guilloche	Fine mathematical line-work used in security printing, extremely difficult to reproduce by scan-and-print. The primary visual security element of a StromeX credential; Volume VI §6.2.
Human-in-the-loop	The requirement that a named human decides, and is recorded as deciding, wherever the stakes ladder classifies a decision as high. Volume IV §8.1.
LTV	Lifetime value. The discounted gross profit expected from a customer over the expected life of the relationship.

TERM	DEFINITION
No-fork rule	The prohibition on forking shared platform layers for a single customer without written CTO approval and a sunset date. Volume IV §3.2.
NRR	Net revenue retention. Recurring revenue from existing customers including expansion and contraction. Above 100% means the existing base grows without new customers.
Pricing Council	The standing body that owns Volume III, meets quarterly, and reviews every price against delivered margin. Volume I §8.4.
Reference Implementation	A delivered institutional deployment used as proof of method and as a permanent sales asset. Four are recorded in this edition.
Rule of 40	Revenue growth percentage plus operating margin percentage. A common composite measure of whether a software company balances growth against profitability.
Stakes ladder	The four-level classification — low, medium, high, prohibited — determining how much autonomy an AI system may exercise over a decision. Volume IV §8.1.
System of record	The authoritative store of an institution's people, money, documents, credentials and decisions. Identified in Volume II §9 as the group's only genuinely durable moat.
Value ledger	The running, honest account of what an institution has gained from StromeX, shown at every renewal including the periods where the numbers are unimpressive. Volume I §4.4.
Verification token	A prepaid unit purchased by an institution for verification-adjacent services carrying real marginal cost. Verification itself is always free to the verifier. Volume III §3.5.
Wave	A group of industry ecosystems opened in the same roadmap phase. Volume I §2.2.

Table 19 — Glossary of terms

References & Bibliography

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Internal sources

Claims in this corpus about what the group has built trace to these. Catalogue lines in Volume III are marked built, partial or specified-not-built on this basis.

StromeX MVP · [apps/api](#), [apps/web](#), [infra](#)

FastAPI backend with multi-provider AI routing, memory, spaced-repetition tutor and PDF export; Next.js frontend; Docker Compose infrastructure. Establishes the canonical stack in Volume IV §2.2.

Independent MVP Audit · [docs/04-STROMEX-INDEPENDENT-AUDIT.md](#)

Security, scalability, reliability and performance audit including a critical server-side request forgery vulnerability found, reproduced and fixed. Carried forward as a standing engineering rule in Volume IV §15.

Reference Implementation №1 · [Sultan Hanafi Royal Schools](#)

Four-language institutional build (English, Arabic RTL, Yorùbá, French) with approximately thirty-five page templates per locale; four verification surfaces; certificate generation with documented identifier architecture, security model and signing-key deployment; digital identity and card system; finance platform; eight role portals; personalisation centre; and approximately one hundred and twenty institutional system, governance and design documents.

Reference Implementation №2 · [WorldWide English College](#)

A seventy-three-table credential and commerce schema across fifteen migrations, covering enrolment integrity, competencies, evidence, awards, credential signing, issued documents, verifying institutions, payments, instalment plans, multi-currency routing, corporate seats and alumni chapters. The evidential basis for Volume IV §4.2.

Reference Implementation №3 · [Al-Madeenah College](#)

Bilingual static build system with offline service worker, verification surfaces, font subsetting pipeline and document generation to PDF and DOCX.

Reference Implementation №4 · [Institutional portal system](#)

Multi-role portal implementation covering student, staff, parent, applicant and administrative roles, admissions pipeline, attendance, timetable, assessment, finance and library.

Index

Generated by the build. Page references point to where each concept is established or substantively discussed; passing mentions are not indexed. Word index markers are also embedded throughout the corpus, so a live index can be built in Word if preferred.

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Colophon

This edition is composed for A4 at 210 × 297 mm. Display matter is set in a serif book face and running text in a companion serif, with a sans for tables, captions and navigation and a monospaced face for code and architecture figures — the four typographic roles defined in Volume I, Chapter 10. The StromeX brand faces, **Archivo** and **Fraunces**, ship with this edition in [docs/bible/publication/fonts/](#); the build selects them automatically wherever they are installed in the rendering environment, so the corpus can be reissued in full brand typography without editing a line of it.

The rules, tables and figures follow the design laws in Volume I, Chapter 12: typography carries the interface, space is a component, colour carries meaning, and structural devices encode something true about the content rather than decorating it. Tables use horizontal rules only; the vertical grid is carried by alignment, as it is in every well-set financial document.

This DOCX is the authoritative master. The press-quality PDF edition is generated from it and is content-identical. Both are produced from the markdown corpus of record under version control at [docs/bible/](#), by the build recorded at [docs/bible/publication/](#), so that the publication can be regenerated exactly whenever the corpus is amended.

THE STROME X EDITORIAL BIBLE · Edition II ·
VERSION 2.0

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